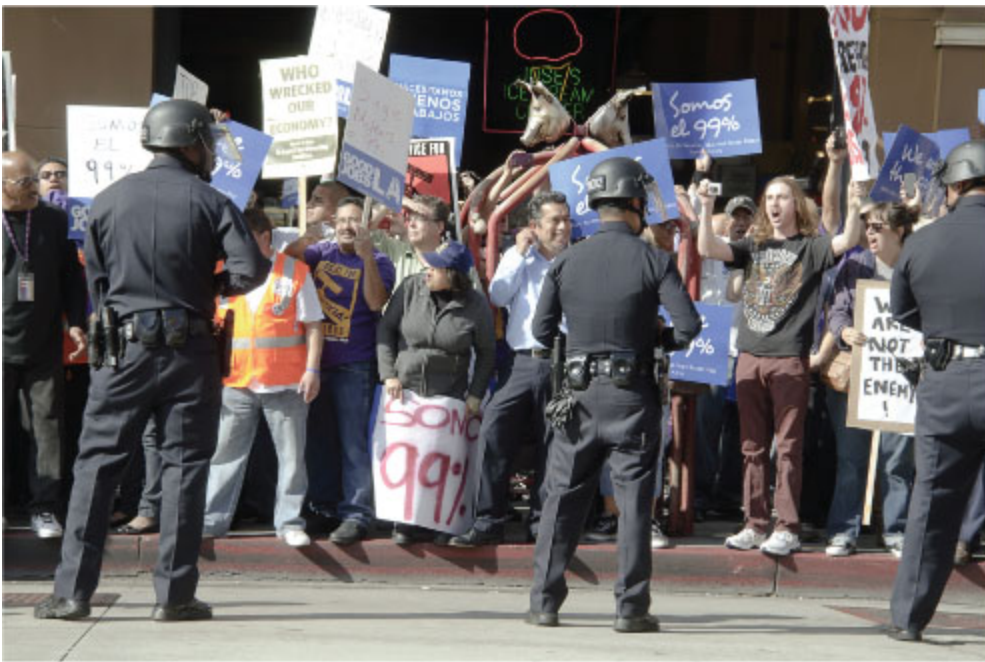


1-5b The Globalization Debate and You

As a future business leader, you are not a detached reader. The globalization debate directly affects *your* future. Therefore, it is imperative that you participate in the globalization debate instead of letting other people make decisions on globalization that will significantly affect your career, your consumption, and your country. It is important to know your own biases when joining the debate. By the very act of taking an IB course and reading this book, you probably already have some pro-globalization biases, compared to non-business majors elsewhere on campus and the general public in your country.

Why do protestors like these object to globalization?



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You are not alone. In the last several decades, most executives, policy makers, and scholars in both developed and emerging economies, who are generally held to be the elite in these societies, are biased toward acknowledging the benefits of globalization. However, many other members of the society do not necessarily share the same views. Unfortunately, many of the elite fail to understand the limits of their beliefs and mistakenly assume that the rest of the world thinks like them. To the extent that powerful economic and political institutions are largely controlled by the elite in almost every country, it is not surprising that some anti-globalization groups, feeling powerless, end up resorting to unconventional tactics, such as mass protests, to make their point.

Many of the opponents of globalization are

nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) (An organization that is not affiliated with governments.)

, such as environmentalists, human rights activists, and consumer groups. Ignoring them will be a grave failure when doing business around the globe. Instead of viewing NGOs as opponents, many firms view them as partners. NGOs do raise a valid point when they insist that firms, especially MNEs, should have a broader concern for the various stakeholders affected by the actions of MNEs actions around the world. At present, this view is increasingly moving from the peripheral to the mainstream (see [Chapters 3](#) and [17](#)).

It is certainly interesting, and perhaps alarming, to note that as would-be business leaders who will shape the global economy in the future, current business school students already exhibit values and beliefs in favor of globalization similar to those held by executives, policy makers, and scholars and different from those held by the general public. Shown in [Table 1.5](#), US business students have significantly more positive (almost one-sided) views toward globalization than does the general public. My lectures around the world suggest that most business students—regardless of their nationality—seem to share such positive views on globalization. This is not surprising. Both self-selection to study business and socialization within the curriculum, in which free trade is widely regarded as positive, may lead to certain attitudes in favor of globalization. Consequently, business students tend to focus more on the economic gains of globalization and to be less concerned with its darker sides.

Table 1.5

Views on Globalization: General Public versus Business Students

Percentage answering “good” for the question: Overall, do you think globalization is <i>good</i> or <i>bad</i> for	General public ¹ (N = 1,024)	Business students ² (N = 494)
US consumers like you	68%	96%
US companies	63%	77%
The US economy	64%	88%
Strengthening poor countries’ economies	75%	82%

Sources: Based on (1) A. Bernstein, 2000, *Backlash against globalization*, *BusinessWeek*, April 24: 43; (2) M. W. Peng & H. Shin, 2008, *How do future business leaders view globalization?* *Thunderbird International Business Review*, 50 (3): 175–182. All differences are statistically significant.

Current and would-be business leaders must be aware of their own biases embodied in such one-sided views toward globalization. Since business schools aspire to train future business leaders by indoctrinating students with the dominant values that managers hold, business schools may have largely succeeded in this mission. However, to the extent that current managers (and professors) have some strategic blind spots, these findings are potentially alarming. They reveal that business students already share these blind spots. Despite possible self-selection in choosing to major in business, there is no denying that student values are shaped, at least in part, by the educational experience that business schools provide. Knowing such limitations, business school professors and students need to work especially hard to break out of this mental straitjacket.

In order to combat the widespread tendency to have one-sided, rosy views, a significant portion of this book is devoted to the numerous debates that surround globalization. Debates are systematically introduced in *every* chapter to provoke more critical thinking—a hallmark for high-level university training. Virtually all textbooks uncritically present knowledge “as is” and ignore the fact that the field is alive with numerous debates. No doubt, debates drive practice and research forward. Therefore, it is imperative that you be exposed to cutting-edge debates and encouraged to form your own views. In addition, business ethics are emphasized throughout the book. A featured Ethical Dilemma can be found in every chapter. Two whole chapters are devoted to ethics, norms, and cultures ([Chapter 3](#)) and corporate social responsibility ([Chapter 17](#)).

Chapter 1: Globalizing Business: 1-5b The Globalization Debate and You

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